

INTRODUCTION

The violent death of Valentinian III, one year after that of Aetius, constitutes an important turning point in the history of the Roman West. It marks the end of the late antique dynastic empire and proclaims the crisis in relations between monarchy and military commands. The immediate effect was a further hardening of relations with the *pars Orientis* and a renewed aggressiveness of the Germanic populations settled in the Roman provinces. The isolation and vulnerability of Rome in turn accentuated the climate of instability in internal relations that had already manifested itself in the age of Stilicho.

- 1 1. 1 The break is underlined by Marcellinus (chron. a. 454): *Aetius magna Occidentalis rei publicae salus et regi Attilae terror a Valentiniano imperatore cum Boethio amico in palatio trucidatur, atque cum ipso Hesperium cecidit regnum nec hactenus valuit relevari*. On this passage, cf. B. Croke, *The Chronicle of Marcellinus. A Translation with Commentary*, Leiden-Boston 1995, 93; M. Kruse, *The politics of Roman Memory. From the Fall of the Western Empire to the Age of Justinian*, Philadelphia 2019, spec. 172-180.
- 2 2. 2 Signs of a crisis in relations between the two parts of the empire emerged when Attila asked Honoria to marry him (G. Zecchini, *Aezio: l'ultima difesa dell'Occidente romano*, Rome 1983, 264-266); these intensified in subsequent years, on the occasion of Marcian's nomination (V. Bain, *Per una nuova interpretazione del regno di Marciano*, *MediterrAnt*, 7 [2004], 373-405, 390-391). Marcian and Leo, on the other hand, do not seem to have played any role in the events of the *pars Occidentis* after 455, where all imperial nominations until 467 were the result of the evolution of internal relations; cf. spec. J. Szidat, *Usurpator tanti nominis. Kaiser und Usurpator in der Spätantike (337-476 AD)*, Stuttgart 2010, 125-130, 283-286, 347-356 et passim; cf. also F. Oppedisano, *L'impero d'Occidente negli anni di Maioriano*, Rome 2013, 51-62; 73-74; 105-118; see also *infra*, chap. III.
- 3 3. 3 For a general overview of the crisis in relations between Rome and the barbarians and the profound changes that mark diplomatic practices in this phase, A. Becker, *Les relations diplomatiques romano-barbares en Occident au Ve siècle. Acteurs, fonctions, modalités*, Paris 2013, 64-82. The most serious episode in the history of the Western Empire was the breaking of pacts with the Vandals, which led to the sack of 455, and which derives, ultimately, from Petronius Maximus's attempt to legitimize his position by breaking the marital promises, guaranteed by Valentinian III and Aetius, between Gaiseric's family and the Theodosian dynasty: U. Roberto, *Roma capta. Il Sacco della città dai Galli ai Lanzichenecchi*, Rome-Bari 2012, 145-146. A worsening of the effects determined by the Vandal conquest of Africa is then recorded (on the periodicizing value of that event, cf. e.g. C. Wickham, *Framing the Early Middle Ages. Europe and the Mediterranean, 400-800*, Oxford 2005, 87-93); in addition to the increasingly frequent Vandal incursions on the coasts of southern Italy and Sicily (*infra*, chap. X), starting from 455, according to Savino, the supplies of *res privata* to Rome stopped, with repercussions on urban demography: E. Savino, *La conquista vandolica dell'Africa e la popolazione di Roma nel V sec. d.C.*, *Athenaeum*, 107 (2019), 156-168; cf. J. Linn, *The Roman Grain Supply, 442-455*, *JLA*, 5 (2012), 298-321. Discusses phenomena of "resilience" after 455, M.R. Salzman, *Emperors and Elites in Rome after the Vandal Sack of 455*, *AntTard*, 25 (2017), 243-263.

and that resulted in a retreat of imperial authority against the strong position of the *magister militum praesentalis* and the senatorial aristocracy⁴. In the twenty-one years between the death of Valentinian III and the deposition of Romulus Augustulus, the government of Rome passed from one emperor to another nine times, with two long periods of interregnum (in 456-457, between the deposition of Avitus and the election of Majorian, and in 465-467, between the death of Libius Severus and the adventus of Anthemius). The figure who, more than any other, was able to maintain a position of strength was Ricimer, who remained at the head of military commands for about sixteen years, until his natural death, which occurred under Olybrius in the summer of 4725. During this period, he outlived four emperors and, in at least three cases, was directly responsible for their deaths⁶. One has the impression of a reversal of roles: while the Roman emperor is unable to choose the military leaders of the *res publica*, a *magister militum* of Germanic origin dictates the rhythm of successions to the throne. The image of an imperial authority now worn out by the competition from the supreme commander of the army has taken root in modern historiography, sometimes in an excessively schematic way: in an empire on the verge of collapse, the last Roman princes often assumed the guise of powerless puppets, manipulated in the shadows by their powerful general. While there have been clarifications aimed at toning down or countering this representation, it has nonetheless enjoyed widespread popularity, favoring a mostly indistinct view of the last Roman emperors of the West. Their profiles tend towards rarefaction, and their personalities end up diluting into a mixture with very distinct characteristics: weak, externally directed, incapable of acting effectively in society and of countering the forces that threatened their integrity from the outside, these bland epigones of the imperial tradition appear committed to reiterating the same failed experience, thus embodying the agony of Rome⁷.

- 1 1. 4 The transformation of power relations between the imperial government and the senatorial aristocracy in the years of Stilicho is one of the fundamental contributions of S. Mazzarino's first book, *Stilicho. The Imperial Crisis after Theodosius*, Milan 1990 (Rome 1942); F. Oppedisano, *Santo Mazzarino and the late antique senate*, *StudStor*, 61 (2020), 27-39.
- 2 2. 5 On Ricimer, see F. Anders, *Flavius Ricimer. Power and Powerlessness of the Western Roman Magister Militum in the Second Half of the 5th Century*, Frankfurt a. M.-Belin-Bern-Brussels-New York-Oxford 2010.
- 3 3. 6 On the deaths of Avitus and Majorian: Oppedisano, *The Western Empire* (cited), 81-90; 273-278; on the death of Anthemius: Roberto, *Rome against Constantinople*, CPh, 65 (1970), 228-240. On the death of Libius Severus: S.I. Oost, D. N. Libius Severus P. F. Aug., CPh, 65 (1970), 228-240.
- 4 4. 7 In relation to the post-Theodosian West, the expression 'shadow emperor' (*Schattenkaiser*) was in use in German works from the early nineteenth century to indicate specific figures, in particular Libius Severus, Glycerius, and Romulus Augustulus: W. Menzen, *The History of the Germans*, 1, *Time of Pagan Antiquity up to Charlemagne*, Zurich 1825, 157; F. Lorentz, *Western Empire*, in *General Encyclopedia of Sciences and Arts in Alphabetical Order*, edited and published by the aforementioned authors J.S. Ersch and J.G. Gruber, with copperplates and maps, III, 1, edited by M.H.E. Meier and L.F. Kämtz, Leipzig 1830, 243-260; 251 and 252; A. Wilhelm, *Odoacer*, *ibid.*, 366-374; 368; L.M. Hartmann, *The Italian Kingdom*, Leipzig 1897, 43. The use of the word *phantôme* precedes this: Libius Severus is defined as «the phantôme of an Emperor created by Ricimer» by J.-C. Royou, *History of the Low Empire, from Constantine, until the fall of Constantinople*, in 1453, I, Paris 1803, 524, while in the French edition of Gibbon's work, translated by M.F. Guizot in 1819, the expression «nominal reign» was rendered with «the reign of this phantôme of an emperor».

Restoring distinct traits to such figures is not easy, and in the most careful treatises on the final years of the Western Roman Empire, the need often arises to distinguish them from each other, associating with the names of the last emperors an epithet capable of distinguishing them from others (Petronius Maximus and the noble Avitus the Gallo-Roman, Majorian the military, Libius Severus the Lucanian, Anthemius the Greek)⁸, or dividing them by typology (the emperors of senatorial origin, the child emperors)⁹. The only experience of government that, with a certain frequency, is recognised as having played a diverse and prominent role is that of Majorian. This, however, is predominantly valued for its eccentric character with respect to the spirit of those years. Majorian seems to have interpreted his role as a tragic hero: a humanity now defiled by barbarism, he wanted to act like a Germanicus or a Trajan more than like a Roman monarch of the fifth century, and for that reason his attempt to revive the fortunes of Rome, however valorous, was destined to inexorably fail¹⁰. In a vision that largely harks back to the Justinianic historiography elaborated by Marcellinus and that tends to assume teleological nuances, the impact of 476 becomes minimal: the deposition of Romulus Augustulus is the natural outcome of the collapse of imperial power that characterises the years succeeding the death of Valentinian III, and the fortunate parable of Ricimer is the prefiguration of that, successive, of the Scirian Odoacer. In the periodisation internal to late antiquity, the tendency emerges to incorporate the two phases 455-476 and 476-493 into a single period of transition between the end of Theodosius I and the beginning of the Ostrogothic monarchy¹¹, during which, with the disintegration of the Roman political and institutional fabric, a new order is established, based on the figure of a military leader of barbarian origin. Aspects in countertendency, failed political experiments or attempts, tend to remain at the margins of an evolutionary process that leads, in sum, from 455 to 476 and then to 493.

- 1 1. (E. Gibbon, *The History of the Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*, IV, ed. J.B. Bury, London 1898 [1788-1789], 25). In T. Hodgkin, *Theodoric the Goth. Barbarian Champion of Civilization*, New York-London 1897, 96-97, 'shadow-emperors' is now altogether associated with the period 455-476 («with the single exception of Majorian»). It is an important passage, because in the course of the '900 these formulas have known a very wide diffusion, especially in Anglophone historiography, both in the form of shadow emperors and of puppet emperors. The dedication of such expressions is such that, even in careful works, in these emperors, some are used to indicate altogether the last twenty years of the Western Roman Empire (see for example R.W. Mathisen, *De imperatoribus Romanis*. An Online Encyclopedia of Roman Emperors, <https://www.roman-emperors.org/libius.htm> [January 2020], where Libius Severus is «the fourth of the so-called 'shadow' or 'puppet' western emperors», or the recent contribution by M. McEvoy, *Shadow Emperors and the Choices of Rome (455-476 AD)*, *AntTard*, 25 [2017], 95-112).
- 2 2. See in particular D. Henning, *Periclitans res publica: Kaisertum und Eliten in der Krise des weströmischen Reiches 454/5-493 n. Chr.*, Stuttgart 1999.
- 3 3. McEvoy, *Shadow Emperors*, whose classification appears arbitrary: if the senatorial profile of Petronius Maximus and Libius Severus, as well as Majorian's military profile, seem to effectively connote these emperors, it is not possible to affirm that Avitus and Anthemius were military for the simple reason that they had assumed military offices.
- 4 4. For the examination of these problems, see Oppédisano, *L'impero d'Occidente*, 9-14.
- 5 5. See, for example, A. Demandt, *Die Spätantike. Römische Geschichte von Diocletian bis Justinian, 284-565 n. Chr.*, München 2007 (1989), 204-217; Henning, *Periclitans res publica*.

Anthemius' experience does not escape this general vision, in fact, it confirms it: his origins and the role played by Leo in his nomination have been interpreted as clear signs of Rome's weakness, but at the same time they constitute the causes of the civil war of 472, as if the Roman West was now spiralling into a condition that prevented it, on the one hand, from independently addressing internal problems and external threats, and, on the other, from accepting the command of a *Graeculus* and the interference of the Byzantine East. An analytical study of Anthemius' figure and his politics – which in this book is carried out for the first time in a systematic way and from a plurality of viewpoints – allows for a different picture to be outlined, both of his role in Italy and of the power dynamics within the *res publica* in the final decades of the Western Roman Empire. His ascent to the throne was not imposed by Constantinople – which, among other things, would not have been able to do so – but was the result of a convergence of interests: in the East, Leo rid himself of an inconvenient figure, already invested in the succession by Marcian (whose daughter Anthemius had married), and could claim credit for having chosen the Augustus of Rome and restored the unity of the *partes*; in the West, the senate, after the failure of Majorian and the inertia of Ricimer, obtained the guarantee of a massive effort against the Vandals: it was precisely from Rome that the delegations moved with which the negotiation for the nomination began, which occurred in the spring of 467. The image of Ricimer's 'shadow government' is strongly downsized by the examination of these events: if after Majorian's death, in 461, he had conducted Rome's military policy with wide margins of autonomy and had been able to represent himself in ways that suggested his figure approximated that of a monarch, his inability to effectively counter Genseric's threats eroded the senate's trust: in 467, his main point of reference in the curia, Decius Basilius, was now a close collaborator of Anthemius. The sixteen years in which Ricimer maintained his position as *magister militum praesentalis* thus escape a homogeneous framework: his aspiration to act beyond the perimeter of the functions strictly connected to his office reached its maximum realization between Majorian and Anthemius. First, in 457, his attempt to assume a leading role in the new imperial government had been frustrated by Majorian's choices, just as later, in 466/467, his ambitions would be forced to retreat in the face of the senate's new orientations. In both cases, external events allowed him to regain ground: the destruction of Majorian's fleet and the failure of Anthemius' military project. It can be affirmed that, at least in these two circumstances, Ricimer's momentary success was favored by Genseric's political stature.

1 1. On this aspect, see below, chap. I.

2 2. See below, chap. IV.

3 3. *Ibid.*

4 4. On the problems related to the powers of the *magister militum praesentalis*, see below, chap. IX (with references to historiographical approaches).

The defeat inflicted on the Roman forces by the king of the Vandals constitutes the main cause of the end of Anthemius' government (as had happened in the case of Majorian). Oriental origins had no weight in the outcome of his political parabola: on the contrary, they had positive reflections on his image, especially in Rome¹⁶. Certainly, the role assumed by the Eastern court could arouse fear of a progressive extension of its authority in the West, but this was the price that the Italian ruling classes were willing to pay in exchange for the commitment to strengthen the Roman military presence in the central Mediterranean. Anthemius' origin is the spy of an ambitious experiment, and the concord between the two *partes imperii*, rediscovered after a period of cold relations, is an expression of the vitality of a world that was experimenting with new strategies to counteract the snares and multiple problems that threatened the integrity of Rome. 455 was also this: a moment of rupture that gave rise to a creative phase in the history of the Western Roman Empire. With the death of Aetius and the end of the Theodosian dynasty, the fragility of the imperial government had worsened, which however did not arise then but descended from the crisis of the age of Stilicho. At that moment, the senatorial aristocracy – which had clear responsibilities in determining that crisis – acted to find a remedy: it did so in a disorganized way, now supporting Ricimer, now favoring – particularly with Majorian and Anthemius – projects that aimed to restore stability to the Roman Empire through the restitution to Rome of the territories lost in Africa and Gaul, and through the centralization, under the direct authority of the Roman emperor, of governmental functions, both civil and military. The choice of themes around which the ten chapters of this volume revolve is based on the intention of combining the analysis of Anthemius' figure with a broader discussion of the Roman West. In the first part, *Between East and West*, three chapters are dedicated to the overall problem of the perception of Greeks in the West, to Anthemius' origins, and to the political relations between the two *partes imperii*; in the second, *Anthemius in Rome*, Anthemius' settlement and the organization of the imperial organizational chart are studied in close connection with the cultural and religious context of the city of Rome; in the third, *Domestic and Military Policy*, the political directions emerging from legislation, the military setup, and the strategies implemented in those years are finally analyzed. The book is part of a larger project, which I have conducted at the Scuola Normale Superiore since 2017, and which simultaneously envisages the publication of a monograph on Anthemius' panegyric. The two works are complementary. I am grateful to the Scuola Normale for having entirely financed the project, to the anonymous reviewers who read this book, and to the authors who contributed to its realization.

1 1. 16 See below, chapters V and VI.